

Mrs. Margaret T. LeDoux

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Winters were often severe and snow-banks sometimes mounted as high as the top of the gabel roof: but poor, dear Father took care before the cold weather set in, to bank well wherever he might, so that we were fairly comfortable no matter how the wind howled or the mercury sank.

You'll be wondering soon, more than before if I keep on in this strain, how it might be called a mansion. Well, every decent mansion has a chapel of some demensions.... Ours was at times all chapel, and at times something of a church. As long as we lived in that little abode - a "hovel" possibly outside but clean and neat as a palace within - we were wont to say our morning and night prayers together; and on Sundays at 10 a.m., Father would read Mass Prayers. Of course when the weather permitted and the roads were anyway decent he would trudge away to church about six miles taking short cuts distant. Then Ellie or James or one of the others would lead the prayers. Sometimes they seemed pretty long. It was on such a Sunday that Papa and Jime had gone to church when we saw the black clous of smoke rising from the far side of some of the hills off to the South. The wind was pretty strong too and poor dear Mother seemed quite anxious - giving instructions what to do and getting ready for what must have looked probable, a burn out. Ellie scratched a little "hoe-mark" out in front of the house and sprinkled holy water in it about half way down to the barn. By this time the fire was crackling through the grass and brush this side of Lam's Road and the smoke rolled over our heads in thick, dark clouds. Then the barn took fire, some ten rods east of the house, and we all went down, carying some bed-clothes, to the lone tree that for a long time stood in the middle of the original four-acre field.

This, I think, must have been about the second summer we lived in Trimbelle. Because we had a new field, if I remember right, of about six acres and the great oaks over to the N. East, among which the prairie chickens at first played and danced were gone; And as we were huddled together under said lone tree (my own little face hidden in Mother's dress from the smoke) I heard Mother saying in accents of relief: "Thanks be to God! some of the neighbors have come and let the pig out". It was a big white one and had broken out of the pen itself where it had been a contented prisoner right near the barn. We saw it running for safety. Papa and James got home shortly after Noon and some of the neighbors came to sympathise with us. It seemed a fresh clear day but our barn was in ruins and the hills were black in every direction, except our fields and up to the N.W. where the fire did not cross the highway. In fact, I do not think it crossed